

- 1 *Bra* 2012
archival pigment print
50 x 50 cm
Courtesy the artist
- 2 *Glove* 2012
archival pigment print
50 x 50 cm
Courtesy the artist
- 3 *Hand* 2012
archival pigment print
50 x 50 cm
Courtesy the artist



1



2



3

ROSEMARY HAWKER

Yavuz Erkan's photographs combine the directness of documentary photography with the intellectual provocation of conceptual art. They are well lit, their compositions formal and consistent. Most can be thought of as self-portraits but some show isolated still-life objects. As much as they are concise and the forms they show readily apparent, they remain open to interpretation and strangely confounding.

An aphorism is a short, instructive saying, direct and to the point, full of meaning and well stated. Erkan's photographs are the visual form of all of these things and yet resist interpretation. They also make us aware that even an aphorism is in danger of depletion through repetition. While based in the history of formal rhetoric and the elegance of language, an aphorism might be undone through its own success. When overly familiar, it becomes conventional, stereotypical, spent. An unorthodox aphorism might then be said to break not just with tradition more broadly but with the convention espoused by the aphorism itself. Erkan says: 'I invite the viewers to distance themselves from their conventional routines. These photographs are visual aphorisms targeted at the conformism of individuals who live what is considered a normal life.'

Erkan's simple photographs identify convention and conformity through their disruption. Each image results from an experiment in placing objects and posing before the camera, making something visible, including our own looking and the acute sense of being seen that self-portraiture relies upon. As much as Erkan is present in this series, he never looks directly at the camera, avoiding a convention that risks overuse in photographic portraiture. The only time he comes close to a direct address to the viewer—in the bubblegum image—he is occluded behind a

YAVUZ ERKAN

breathly screen of diaphanous gum. Each of these alignments of the artist's body with everyday things—rubber gloves, a balloon, a glass of milk, an urn, a bra, bubblegum—open onto various forms of pleasure, in touch, or sight, or taste. This sensual array avoids ponderous over-elaboration and is instead grounded in humour and even self-parody. In understanding this, we also see the stereotypes these quietly ambitious images deride.

Erkan's body surprises us by simply being outside photography's standard representations of masculinity. Through that surprise, the pervasiveness of those stereotypes is delivered like a little shock. This gentle rupture in the representation of the masculine is underscored by Erkan using visual tropes of the feminine in art: the domestic interior, the twisted towel turban, an averted face and sensuous curving back. It is disarming how economically and directly Erkan resists the orthodoxy and disturbs our expectations. He gently teases and provokes us towards recognising our conformity, our comfort in playing by the rules, through the strangest of triggers: a wobbling jelly is held in a cupped hand, a hand is stuffed into a glass of milk, a bra cup is used as if a face mask. These light-hearted incongruities are presented through a deadpan photography that recalls the formal strategies of Ed Ruscha or Douglas Huebler. As Huebler said: 'I'm not trying to prove anything. It's kind of like setting the strategy and just doing that and seeing what I got.' This seems equally true of Erkan's photographs and their skilful play between rule making and breaking and the visual rhetoric of the aphorism.

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